The present perfect vs the past simple

Goal: By the end of this lesson, you will be able to choose between the present perfect (*has written*) and the past simple (*wrote*) when you talk about the achievements of a living or a dead person.

The idea in two lines: The **past simple** is for a finished action at a definite past time (*She wrote her first novel in 1995*). The **present perfect** (have / has + past participle) links the past to now: the time is not given or the period is not finished (*She has written ten novels so far*).

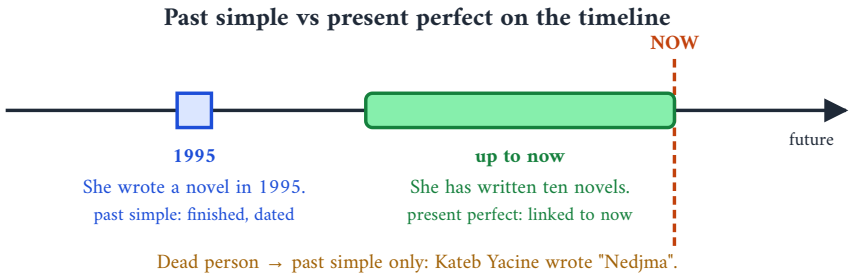


Figure 1: A dated, closed action takes the past simple; an action in a period that reaches the present takes the present perfect.

🔵 Rules and concepts

1. **Form of the present perfect:** *have / has + past participle. He has painted.* Negative: *hasn't / haven't.* Question: *Has she ever won a prize?*
2. **Past simple = definite past time:** *yesterday, last year, in 2010, ago.* The action is over and cut from the present.
3. **Present perfect = indefinite time or unfinished period:** *ever, never, already, yet, just, so far, this year, since, for.*
4. **Since and for:** *since* + starting point (*since 2015*); *for* + duration (*for ten years*).
5. **Living vs dead people:** a living artist can take the present perfect (*She has published three books*); a dead person's life is always in the past simple (*Shakespeare wrote many plays*).

6. A typical pair: **present perfect first, then details in the past simple**. *I have visited Timgad. I went there in 2022.*

🟢 Examples

1. Choose: *Assia Djebar (write / wrote / has written) her first novel in 1957.* **Answer:** wrote. **Explanation:** "in 1957" is a definite past time, so past simple.
2. Choose: *Our teacher (read / has read) this biography several times, and she still loves it.* **Answer:** has read. **Explanation:** no date, and the result continues up to now.
3. Complete with since or for: *Yasmina Khadra has been a writer … more than 30 years.* **Answer:** for. **Explanation:** "30 years" is a duration; *since* would need a starting date.

🟠 Common BEM mistakes

- Present perfect with a past date: "He *has died* in 1989." A date needs the past simple: *He died in 1989.*
- Past simple form after *have*: "She has *wrote*" instead of *has written*.
- Confusing *since* and *for*: "since five years", "for 2010".
- Present perfect about a dead person: "Mozart has composed" instead of *Mozart composed*.

🟡 Quick review

- Past simple: finished action with a definite time (ago, last, in 1990).
- Present perfect: have / has + PP; time not given or still open.
- Key words: ever, never, already, yet, just, so far, since, for.
- since + point in time; for + length of time.
- Dead person → past simple only.

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